

Two new iMacs

Apple has rolled out two new iMac models with intel core 2 duo processors.



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TRIED & TESTED

Acer Aspire NX4440

The Acer Aspire NX4440 is one of the few neatest pieces of hardware you can provision for an additional fan at the front of the case. Although the ultra-widescreen LCD with the 16:10 aspect ratio was the common component sent to us for all the Acer desktops, the keyboard, mouse and

The keyboard is neatly designed as well. The keys are as they are with most other desktop PCs but this has a few interesting things like the volume knob on the right top of the keyboard. The mouse too is sleek but is too light and sort-of flimsy.

With the kind of hardware there is on this Acer and the form factor used, it makes a decent HTPC solution you can connect to a large TV using its HDMI connectivity. Performance in the benchmarks was also satisfactory despite the lack of 2 GB of RAM. For example, Doom 3 and Far Cry fared well. At 800 x 600 with medium quality, it was able to run Doom 3 at 35.7 frames per second. 3D Mark and the graphics component of PC Mark too showed good performance.

The verdict is straight forward once you get to the price. The NX4440 is priced at just Rs. 29,299 which makes very good value for money if you want a system as a HTPC or even otherwise.

Acer Entra E961

The Acer Entra E961 is another basic desktop powered by one of the entry-level low power processors from AMD – the Athlon LE-1620. In appearance, it's even simpler looking than the Aspire IE3222. The front panels feel cheap and plastic but the frame itself is sturdy and designed well. It's an everyday basic-computing case with no

specialties. The case only has two slots for two 5.25-inch and two 3.5-inch drives.

The case is tidy though. A simple cooling solution, a cleanly setup interior and a rear fan ensures effective cooling. The cabinet is dense and can accommodate large graphics cards if necessary. There is also provision for an additional fan at the front of the case. There is only 1 GB of memory on the system so running Vista on it automatically is a big no-no. There are four slots in all for memory expansion so upgrading is possible. The nForce 430 is an old solution and it's the one used in the case of the Entra E961.

With this configuration, the Entra E961 doesn't do a lot to fight against the other desktops for performance rankings but the onboard graphics solution does show its power in the game benchmarks. In FarCry, it scored a fairly impressive 71.37 frames per second. The old nForce chipset is still pretty decent for some basic gaming.

At Rs. 23,099, it's average value for money system. It's an underpowered system but is OK if you plan on using it with a couple of known applications for a very long period of time without any plans of upgrading the system.

Dell OptiPlex 960

Dell's are generally known for their quality and performance but also for being a bit on the higher side of the price bracket with their products. The OptiPlex is one of the elite business desktops. Business desktops are meant strictly for office use, so they should be fast for desktop use and preferably be small to occupy the least bit of space. The Dell brings a bit of excitement



Acer Aspire NX4440

obviously the main case were different. This is one of the really compact systems we've seen and it looks really pretty.

The front has a really glossy finish and houses the audio, USB connectors along side the memory card reader that reads pretty much every format. There's even a tiny Firewire port in the front. The Acer Aspire branding along the side adds to the style element of this system. The top has a flap which when pressed powers on the system. The build of the system is pretty good as well.

With the case open, things get even more interesting. A large cooler sits in the center of the GeForce 8200 board used for the AMD Athlon X2 5000+ processor. The hardware used is a pretty good combination for all kind of work. It's a shame that only a gigabyte of memory was used in the system sent to us. Opt for 2GB of memory if you can. The configuration is just about right for playing back HD 1080p content on it too. A full sized DVD writer and a standard 3.5-inch 320 GB desktop drive is used in it.

The case has been designed well. Most of the cables have a synthetic sheathing around them and are routed through the gaps along the sides of the case. A PCIe x1 and a full sized PCIe x16 slot are also present in case you want to upgrade your graphics solution but the space for a large card may not be present in this particular cabinet. The power supply used is a narrower and long one which is present in most cabinets of this kind. There are support frames built for the power supply resting on the optical drive. Everything is sturdy and there is no wobbling, shaking or sounds from vibrations in this case.

How We Tested



Product testing was done in the same manner as it with desktops in the past and somewhat like laptops. All the products were tested with the operating systems they came with. In almost every case, the vendor installed Windows Vista. There were one or two that came with Windows XP. Many of the desktops had proprietary software installed and some even with antivirus. All of this software which would affect performance was removed and only then were the tests run.

The staple diet of any test to do with desktops and laptops includes the PCMark and 3DMark suites which give a good indication of the core system performance. We used PCMark 2005 and 3D Mark 2005 as the benchmarks. This was done keeping in mind the kinds of desktops we were testing. We were most interested in the CPU score from the 3D Mark 2005 test. There were also test focusing on real world applications that users would use. Cinebench would be used to measure performance at rendering which was mostly was highly dependent on the processor and on the system memory. Similarly, the WinRAR benchmark would measure the performance. SiSoft would give us a drive index value for the hard drive performance but we also did a simple file copy test to gauge the hard drive performance in a real world situation.

As always, weights for the tests were distributed evenly among the benchmarks. The focus was on performance on the desktop and also on the graphics performance. A lot of points were distributed to the features component. For example, the size of the display, resolution and hard drive space and memory played an important part in the test. Importance was given to the upgradability offered by the system. This was mostly to do with the number of free slots for memory and the ability to add an extra graphics card in the future. Number of SATA ports, USB and Firewire formed the other numbers which would add up the features part of the ratings. Of course, performance numbers would come from what we thought of the quality of the case, how well the screen and speakers performed. Weights were allotted also to the ergonomics of the keyboard and mouse.